

****ICSE CLASS 10 ENGLISH LITERATURE — COMPLETE REVISION NOTES****

****DRAMA: JULIUS CAESAR BY WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE****

**** JULIUS CAESAR: ACT 3 ****

****YouTube Lecture:**** <https://youtu.be/LP663WSAgLY?si=HIWgrDMUKaxbUYti>

****1. Scene 1: The Assassination of Caesar****

The scene takes place on the Ides of March (15th March) at the Capitol. Caesar arrives with his senators, including Brutus, Cassius, Casca, Decius, and others. On the way, Artemidorus tries to give Caesar a letter warning him of the conspiracy, but Caesar arrogantly pushes it aside, saying that what touches himself will be served last. Metellus Cimber pleads for the recall of his banished brother, Publius Cimber, from exile. Brutus, Cassius, and other conspirators kneel in apparent support, but Caesar remains firm and refuses to repeal the banishment. He compares himself to the Northern Star, constant and unmovable. At this moment, Casca strikes the first blow, and all the conspirators, including Brutus, stab Caesar. Caesar's last words are, "Et tu, Brute? Then fall, Caesar!" expressing his shock at seeing his close friend Brutus among the murderers.

****2. The Aftermath of the Assassination****

After the murder, the conspirators wash their hands in Caesar's blood and proclaim, "Liberty! Freedom! Tyranny is dead!" Brutus tries to calm the panic among the senators and assures them that no one else will be harmed. Antony's servant arrives with a message from Antony, who pledges loyalty to Brutus if he is allowed to come safely and hear the reasons for Caesar's death. Brutus agrees and Antony arrives. Antony is deeply grieved at Caesar's body. He shakes hands with each conspirator, symbolically staining his own hands with blood. Antony then asks for permission to speak at Caesar's funeral. Cassius strongly objects, fearing that Antony will sway the public against them. Brutus, however, overrules Cassius and grants permission on the condition that Antony will not blame the conspirators but only praise Caesar. Antony agrees but secretly plans to rouse the people against the conspirators.

****3. Antony's Soliloquy****

Left alone with Caesar's body, Antony delivers a powerful soliloquy. He expresses deep sorrow and foretells that a dreadful curse will fall upon Italy. He says, "Cry Havoc! and let slip the dogs of war," meaning that he will unleash the fury of civil war. He invokes Caesar's spirit to seek revenge and predicts that chaos, destruction, and bloodshed will follow. This soliloquy reveals Antony's true intentions: to take revenge on the conspirators.

****4. Scene 2: The Forum Scene — Brutus's Speech****

Brutus addresses the Roman citizens and explains the reasons for the assassination. In his logical and stoic speech, he says that he loved Caesar but loved Rome more. He argues that Caesar was ambitious and would have made the Romans slaves. He asks whether anyone is so base that he would wish to be a bondman. The crowd is convinced and shouts that Brutus should be given a statue and made Caesar.

****5. Scene 2: Antony's Speech****

Antony then rises to speak. Brutus has left the condition that Antony must not blame the conspirators. Antony uses masterful irony and rhetoric. He repeatedly calls Brutus and the conspirators "honourable men," while systematically proving that Caesar was not ambitious. He gives specific examples: Caesar refused the crown three times, he wept with the poor, and his will left money and his private gardens to every Roman citizen. Antony then dramatically reveals Caesar's bloodied cloak and points to the wounds made by the conspirators, especially the "unkindest cut of all" by Brutus. The crowd is completely turned against the conspirators. Antony reads Caesar's will, which leaves every citizen 75 drachmas and opens his private walks and orchards for public use. The enraged citizens now chase the conspirators out of Rome.

****6. Scene 3: The Killing of Cinna the Poet****

Scene 3 shows the mob frenzy. The angry mob mistakes Cinna the Poet for Cinna the Conspirator simply because they share the same name. Despite his pleas that he is not the conspirator, the mob kills him brutally. This scene illustrates how easily mob violence can be manipulated and how innocent people suffer in the chaos of civil war.

****IMPORTANT QUESTIONS: JULIUS CAESAR ACT 3****

****Q1.**** Describe the assassination of Julius Caesar. What were his last words and what did they signify?

****Q2.**** How does Caesar react to the petitions presented by Metellus Cimber and the other conspirators? What does this reveal about Caesar's character?

****Q3.**** Compare and contrast the funeral speeches of Brutus and Antony. How does Antony succeed in turning the crowd against the conspirators?

****Q4.**** What arguments does Brutus give to the Roman citizens to justify the killing of Caesar?

****Q5.**** Explain Antony's soliloquy over Caesar's body. What does he mean by "Cry Havoc! and let slip the dogs of war"?

****Q6.**** How does Antony use Caesar's will as a powerful weapon in his speech?

****Q7.**** Why does Cassius object to Antony speaking at Caesar's funeral? Why does Brutus overrule him? What is the consequence of this decision?

****Q8.**** What is the significance of the scene involving Cinna the Poet?

****Q9.**** How does Antony prove to the crowd that Caesar was not ambitious?

****Q10.**** What is the role of the mob (the common people) in Act 3? How does Shakespeare portray them?

****JULIUS CAESAR: ACT 4****

****YouTube Lecture:**** <https://youtu.be/lG0Vi8XyR0o?si=X8AwofliivLue-JW3>

****1. Scene 1: The Triumvirate****

The second triumvirate is formed by Mark Antony, Octavius Caesar (Caesar's adopted heir), and Lepidus. They meet at a house in Rome and draw up a list of people who must be executed, including their own relatives (Antony agrees to the death of his own nephew). This shows how cold-blooded and ruthless they have become. Antony then sends Lepidus to fetch Caesar's will. Once Lepidus leaves, Antony belittles him to Octavius, saying Lepidus is a "barren-spirited fellow" only fit to be sent on errands. Antony compares Lepidus to a donkey who carries the load but is not a leader. Octavius defends Lepidus slightly but ultimately agrees with Antony. The scene establishes that Octavius and Antony will be the real powers. The triumvirate then prepares to march against the army of Brutus and Cassius.

****2. Scene 2: Brutus and Cassius — Growing Tensions****

Brutus and Cassius are camped near Sardis (in Asia Minor). Cassius arrives, and Brutus immediately takes him inside his tent, away from the soldiers. This is because he does not want their argument to be heard by their army. Brutus accuses Cassius of corruption. He says that Cassius has been accepting bribes and selling positions of authority. Brutus reminds Cassius that they killed Caesar because of his ambition and to establish justice, but if they themselves are corrupt, they are no better than Caesar.

****3. Scene 3: The Quarrel Scene****

Inside Brutus's tent, a heated argument takes place. Brutus directly accuses Cassius of having an "itching palm" (accepting bribes) and of denying Brutus money to pay his legions. Cassius is deeply hurt and offers his dagger to Brutus, challenging him to strike if he truly thinks him so dishonest. Brutus calms down and the two reconcile. They shake hands, and Cassius accepts Brutus's explanation. A poet enters the tent and tries to give advice, but he is rudely dismissed. The two generals then turn to military matters. Brutus reveals that Portia, his wife, has committed suicide by swallowing hot coals, overcome with grief at the growing power of Antony

and Octavius. Cassius is shocked and mourns her death, but Brutus stoically says he will bear the grief and not speak more of it.

****4. The Military Strategy and Caesar's Ghost****

Messala brings news that the triumvirate (Antony and Octavius) has executed hundreds of senators (including Cicero). The enemy army is marching towards Philippi. Cassius advises that they should wait at Sardis and let the enemy exhaust itself by marching a long distance. Brutus disagrees, arguing that the enemy will grow stronger by recruiting more men along the way, while their own army is at its peak now. He insists on marching to Philippi and engaging the enemy there. Cassius reluctantly agrees. That night, as Brutus tries to read, the ghost of Caesar appears to him. The ghost identifies itself as "Thy evil spirit, Brutus" and says, "Thou shalt see me at Philippi." Deeply disturbed, Brutus wakes his attendants but learns that they have seen nothing. He sends orders for the army to march at dawn.

****IMPORTANT QUESTIONS: JULIUS CAESAR ACT 4****

****Q1.**** What was the Second Triumvirate? How did Antony treat Lepidus and what does this reveal about his character?

****Q2.**** Describe the quarrel between Brutus and Cassius. Why did Brutus accuse Cassius?

****Q3.**** What was Cassius's reaction to Brutus's accusations? How was the quarrel resolved?

****Q4.**** What news does Brutus receive about Portia? How does he react to it?

****Q5.**** What difference of opinion arose between Brutus and Cassius regarding the military strategy? Whose strategy was adopted and why?

****Q6.**** Describe the appearance of Caesar's ghost to Brutus. What message did the ghost give?

****Q7.**** What does the argument in Brutus's tent reveal about the state of the conspirators' cause?

****Q8.**** Explain why Brutus called Cassius's honesty into question. Do you think Brutus was justified?

****Q9.**** How does Octavius emerge as a strong, silent character in Act 4?

****Q10.**** Why does Brutus refuse to speak further about Portia's death?

****JULIUS CAESAR: ACT 5****

****YouTube Lecture:**** https://youtu.be/eCTiwm2k4_k?si=ykVdmkZLepgyZ1k0

****1. Scene 1: Before the Battle of Philippi****

The opposing armies meet on the plains of Philippi. Before the battle, Octavius, Antony, Brutus, and Cassius exchange bitter words (parley). Octavius asserts his authority by defying Antony's instructions, showing that he is now a confident leader. Cassius tells Messala that it is his birthday and that he has seen bad omens. He reveals to Messala that he has lost confidence in their cause because two mighty eagles that fed from the hands of soldiers have been replaced by ravens, crows, and kites hovering over the army like a sickly prey. Despite the omen, Cassius says he is ready to face death. Brutus says that if they lose, he will never be taken captive to Rome and paraded in chains.

****2. Scene 2 and 3: The Battle and Cassius's Death****

The battle begins. Brutus's forces initially overpower Octavius's wing. However, on the other side, Cassius's forces are surrounded by Antony. Cassius, observing from a hill, misidentifies the situation. His eyesight is weak, and he sees his own soldiers being captured and tents set on fire. He sends Titinius to confirm. His loyal friend Pindarus (who was made a captive by Cassius and later freed) reports wrongly that Titinius has been captured. Believing all is lost, Cassius asks Pindarus to kill him. He covers his face, and Pindarus stabs him with the very same sword that killed Caesar. Cassius's last words are, "Caesar, thou art revenged, even with the sword that killed thee." Titinius, upon finding Cassius dead, places a victory wreath on his head and then kills himself. Brutus arrives and mourns Cassius, calling him "The last of all the Romans."

****3. Scene 4: The Heroic Death of Lucilius****

Lucilius, a loyal soldier of Brutus, pretends to be Brutus himself and surrenders to the enemy. This buys Brutus time. When Antony's soldiers bring "Brutus" to Antony, Lucilius reveals his identity and proudly declares that Brutus will never be taken alive. Antony admires his bravery and orders that Lucilius be treated well, preferring such men as friends rather than enemies.

****4. Scene 5: Brutus's Death****

Brutus, defeated, asks his soldiers Strato, Clitus, Dardanius, and Volumnius to help him die. One by one they refuse. Finally, Strato agrees to hold the sword, and Brutus runs onto it. Brutus's last words express his deep conviction that he acted honourably for the sake of Rome. Antony and Octavius arrive and discover Brutus's body. Antony delivers a noble tribute to Brutus, calling him "the noblest Roman of them all." Antony says that while all the other conspirators acted out of envy of great Caesar, only Brutus acted with pure motives, thinking of the common good. Octavius orders that Brutus's body be honoured with all rites of burial.

****IMPORTANT QUESTIONS: JULIUS CAESAR ACT 5****

****Q1.**** Describe the exchange between the opposing generals before the Battle of Philippi.

****Q2.**** How does Cassius meet his end? What is the significance of his last words, "Caesar, thou art revenged"?

****Q3.**** What caused Cassius to believe that defeat was certain? Was his action justified?

****Q4.**** Describe the noble sacrifice of Titinius. What does this reveal about his loyalty?

****Q5.**** How does Lucilius demonstrate his loyalty to Brutus? What does this tell us about Brutus's leadership?

****Q6.**** Describe the death of Brutus. What were his last words and what did they signify?

****Q7.**** State the tribute Antony pays to Brutus at the end. Why does he call Brutus "the noblest Roman of them all"?

****Q8.**** What orders does Octavius give regarding Brutus's body?

****Q9.**** How does Octavius's character develop in Act 5?

****Q10.**** What is the importance of the omens in Act 5? How does Shakespeare use them to build the atmosphere?

****TREASURE CHEST: PROSE (SHORT STORIES)****

****PROSE 1: WITH THE PHOTOGRAPHER BY STEPHEN LEACOCK****

****YouTube Lecture:**** <https://www.youtube.com/live/vxG2i1Pvnl0?si=aVW2S84UHAIASKES>

****1. Summary of the Story****

The story is a humorous account of the narrator's visit to a photographer's studio to get his photograph taken. It is a satire on the artificiality of professional photography and the gap between how we see ourselves and how others see us. The narrator describes his torturous experience with the photographer, who criticises his face as "quite wrong" and proceeds to manipulate him physically and then manipulate the photo negative. The shocking final result is a photo that resembles nobody the narrator knows. The story ends with the biting remark that the

photograph looked like "a worthless bauble" and the photographer's comment that he had "lived in vain."

****2. Character Analysis****

****The Narrator:**** He is an ordinary man who wants a simple photograph. He is irritated, humiliated, and shocked by the photographer's arrogance and the drastic alterations made to his face. He represents every individual who expects a truthful, natural record of his appearance.

****The Photographer:**** He is a pompous, arrogant, and highly artificial professional. He believes he knows better than nature and completely dehumanises the narrator in the photograph. He is obsessed with technical perfection at the cost of truth and natural likeness.

****3. Themes****

The story satirises the artificiality of modern art and photography that prioritises technical perfection over natural human likeness.

The conflict between reality and representation: how we truly look versus how the camera (and the photographer) chooses to represent us.

The dehumanising effect of technology and professionalism.

****IMPORTANT QUESTIONS: WITH THE PHOTOGRAPHER****

****Q1.**** Describe the narrator's experience at the photographer's studio. What were the different stages of his ordeal?

****Q2.**** How does the photographer criticise the narrator's face? What does this reveal about the photographer's attitude?

****Q3.**** What is the significance of the title "With the Photographer"? Is it an appropriate title?

****Q4.**** Explain how humour is created in the story through the contrast between the narrator's expectations and the final photograph.

****Q5.**** How does the author satirise the photographic profession and the idea of artificial perfection?

****Q6.**** Why was the narrator shocked when he saw his final photograph? What did the photograph look like?

****Q7.**** What is the narrator's concluding reflection about the photograph? What does he mean by saying the photographer had "lived in vain"?

****Q8.**** Describe the character of the photographer. Was he a good photographer? Support your answer with examples.

****PROSE 2: THE ELEVATOR BY WILLIAM SLEATOR****

****YouTube Lecture:**** <https://www.youtube.com/live/vxG2i1Pvnl0?si=aVW2S84UHAIASKES>

****1. Summary of the Story****

Martin, a thin, weak, and self-conscious twelve-year-old boy, moves into a new apartment building with his father. He develops an intense fear of the elevator after an encounter with a strange, enormously fat woman who gets into the elevator with him. The woman stares at him silently, which terrifies him. He tries to avoid the elevator by taking the stairs, but his father mocks his fear and forces him to face it. One day, Martin injures his leg and is forced to use the elevator. The same fat woman gets in. This time, the elevator stops between floors, and the woman says his name, "Hello, Martin," and laughs. The story ends on a deeply suspenseful note, leaving Martin trapped and terrified.

****2. Character Analysis****

****Martin:**** A thin, frail, and sensitive twelve-year-old boy. He is insecure about his physical weakness and is bullied at school. His fear is largely psychological, but the story leaves it ambiguous whether the woman is real or supernatural.

****Martin's Father:**** He is a practical man who dismisses Martin's fears as childishness. He forces Martin to be tough and face his fear without offering empathy.

****The Fat Lady:**** She is the mysterious antagonist. Her enormous size and silent, penetrating stare create an atmosphere of horror. She may represent Martin's deepest fears or be a supernatural entity.

****3. Themes****

Fear and the power of the unknown. The story plays on the fear of enclosed spaces (claustrophobia) and the fear of being trapped.

Loneliness and isolation of a child who cannot express his fears to his parents.

The irrational nature of fear and how it can be magnified by imagination.

****IMPORTANT QUESTIONS: THE ELEVATOR****

****Q1.**** Who was Martin? Why was he afraid of the elevator?

****Q2.**** Describe the fat woman who enters the elevator. What effect does she have on Martin?

****Q3.**** Why did Martin's father force him to use the elevator? What does this reveal about the father's character?

****Q4.**** What happened when Martin injured his leg and was forced to take the elevator?

****Q5.**** The story ends with the line "Hello, Martin". What is the significance of this ending?

****Q6.**** In your opinion, was the fat woman real or a product of Martin's imagination? Justify your answer.

****Q7.**** How does the setting of the elevator contribute to the atmosphere of horror in the story?

****Q8.**** What role does Martin's physical weakness play in shaping his personality and fears?

****PROSE 3: THE GIRL WHO CAN BY AMA ATA AIDOO****

****YouTube Lecture:**** <https://www.youtube.com/live/vxG2i1Pvnl0?si=aVW2S84UHAIASKES>

****1. Summary of the Story****

The story is narrated by Adjoa, a young Ghanaian girl, who describes her relationship with her mother and her grandmother (Nana). Nana constantly criticises Adjoa's thin, spindly legs, believing they are useless for a woman. She thinks legs should be strong and sturdy to do women's work. Adjoa is sensitive about her legs and tries to hide them. However, she discovers her talent for running. Despite Nana's disapproval, Adjoa goes on to win a school sports competition and her legs, which were a source of shame, become a source of pride. At the end, Nana buys shoes for Adjoa and proudly proclaims that she supports her granddaughter now. The story ends with Adjoa's symbolic reflection that she has found her voice and can now speak her mind.

****2. Character Analysis****

****Adjoa:**** A seven-year-old girl (in the main narrative) who is sensitive, observant, and curious. She is hurt by Nana's constant criticism but grows to discover her own strength. She is the "girl who can".

****Nana (Grandmother):**** An elderly, traditional, and dominant woman who holds fixed ideas about what a woman's body and role should be. She constantly criticises Adjoa's legs. However, she eventually accepts and supports her granddaughter's talent.

****Mother (Maami):**** Adjoa's mother is a quiet, peace-loving woman who mostly remains silent to avoid arguments with Nana.

****3. Themes****

The story challenges traditional gender roles and stereotypes about a woman's body.

The importance of recognising and nurturing individual talent, even when it defies societal expectations.

The inter-generational conflict between traditional thinking and the aspirations of the younger generation.

****IMPORTANT QUESTIONS: THE GIRL WHO CAN****

****Q1.**** Who is the narrator of the story? What is her main insecurity?

****Q2.**** Describe Nana's character. Why does she constantly criticise Adjoa's legs?

****Q3.**** What event changes Nana's attitude towards Adjoa? How does she show her support?

****Q4.**** Explain the significance of the title "The Girl Who Can".

****Q5.**** What does Adjoa mean when she says that she has found her voice at the end of the story?

****Q6.**** How does the story highlight gender stereotypes regarding the female body?

****Q7.**** Describe the relationship between Nana and Adjoa's mother (Maami). What role does Maami play in the story?

****Q8.**** What is the central theme or message of the story?

****PROSE 4: THE PEDESTRIAN BY RAY BRADBURY****

****YouTube Lecture:**** <https://www.youtube.com/live/vxG2i1Pvnl0?si=aVW2S84UHAIASKES>

****1. Summary of the Story****

The story is set in a dystopian future in the year 2053 AD. In this technologically advanced world, people spend their evenings indoors, completely absorbed in their television screens ("viewing screens"). Leonard Mead, the protagonist, is an anomaly. He loves walking alone through the silent, empty streets at night, just as people used to do in earlier times. One night, he is stopped by a robotic police car (the only police car in the entire city). The mechanical voice interrogates him and finds his activity of walking suspicious and abnormal. When Mead says he does not have a viewing screen, a profession (he is a writer in a world that does not read), or a wife, the car concludes he is regressive and decides to take him to the "Psychiatric Centre for Research on Regressive Tendencies." The story ends with Mead being locked in the police car and driven away, while the empty streets remain silent.

****2. Character Analysis****

****Leonard Mead:**** He is a non-conformist in a conformist world. He represents old values of nature, solitude, and the simple pleasure of walking. He is an individual who refuses to be enslaved by technology. His apprehension by the state shows how totalitarian regimes punish difference.

****The Police Car:**** It represents the cold, impersonal, and authoritarian power of a technological state. It has no human driver, no compassion, and no ability to understand or appreciate individual differences.

****3. Themes****

The dehumanising effect of technology and, particularly, the dangers of television culture.

The suppression of individuality and independent thought by a conformist society.

The loss of simple human pleasures like walking, reading, and connecting with nature in a technologically driven world.

****IMPORTANT QUESTIONS: THE PEDESTRIAN****

****Q1.**** Describe the setting of the story "The Pedestrian". What was the world like in 2053?

****Q2.**** Who was Leonard Mead? Why was he considered odd or regressive by society?

****Q3.**** Describe Mead's encounter with the police car. What questions was he asked, and what were his answers?

****Q4.**** Why was Mead arrested? Where was he being taken?

****Q5.**** What is the significance of the police car having no human driver?

****Q6.**** Explain the title "The Pedestrian". Why is walking considered a crime in this society?

****Q7.**** Comment on the theme of technology versus human nature in the story.

****Q8.**** What criticism of modern society does Ray Bradbury make through this story?

****PROSE 5: THE LAST LESSON BY ALPHONSE DAUDET****

****YouTube Lecture:**** <https://www.youtube.com/live/vxG2i1Pvnl0?si=aVW2S84UHAIASKES>

****1. Summary of the Story****

The story is set in the time of the Franco-Prussian War (1870-71). France has been defeated, and the provinces of Alsace and Lorraine have been annexed by Germany. The new German rulers issue an order that from the next day, only German is to be taught in the schools of these provinces. The narrator, a French schoolboy named Franz, arrives at his school one morning to find a strange, solemn atmosphere. His teacher, M. Hamel, is dressed in his finest clothes. M. Hamel then announces that this is the last French lesson they will ever have. The order has come that from tomorrow, only German is to be taught. He delivers a moving lesson about the importance of language. He says, "When a people are enslaved, as long as they hold fast to their language, it is as if they have the key to their prison." Franz, for the first time, deeply regrets not having taken his lessons seriously. The villagers are also present at the back of the class to honour M. Hamel and their language. As the clock strikes, M. Hamel, too choked with emotion to speak, writes "Vive La France!" (Long Live France!) on the blackboard.

****2. Character Analysis****

****Franz:**** The young narrator who is initially lazy and afraid of being scolded. The shock of the announcement transforms him. He becomes attentive, regretful, and deeply emotional about losing his language. His journey from indifference to patriotism is the core of the story.

****M. Hamel:**** The faithful, dedicated French teacher who has taught in the village for forty years. He is calm, gentle, and deeply sad, but he conducts his last lesson with great dignity and passion. His love for his mother tongue and his country is evident in every word.

****3. Themes****

The importance of language as a symbol of cultural identity and freedom.

Patriotism and the pain of losing one's motherland and mother tongue.

Regret for missed opportunities and the realisation of the value of education only when it is about to be taken away.

****IMPORTANT QUESTIONS: THE LAST LESSON****

****Q1.**** Describe the unusual scene at the school when Franz arrived on the day of the last lesson.

****Q2.**** What announcement did M. Hamel make to the class? Why were the villagers present in the classroom?

****Q3.**** Explain M. Hamel's statement, "When a people are enslaved, as long as they hold fast to their language, it is as if they have the key to their prison." What does he mean?

****Q4.**** How did the announcement of the last lesson affect Franz? Describe his feelings and how they changed.

****Q5.**** Describe M. Hamel's behaviour and emotions during the last lesson. What did he do at the very end?

****Q6.**** What is the significance of the title "The Last Lesson"?

****Q7.**** What message does the author Alphonse Daudet want to convey through the story?

****Q8.**** How does the story highlight the theme of patriotism and the value of one's native language?

****TREASURE CHEST: POETRY****

****POEM 1: HAUNTED HOUSES BY H.W. LONGFELLOW****

****YouTube Lecture:**** <https://www.youtube.com/live/vxG2i1Pvnl0?si=aVW2S84UHAIASKES>

****1. Summary of the Poem****

The poem describes how all houses that men have lived and died in are haunted. The poet does not use 'haunted' in the supernatural, frightening sense. Instead, he says that the spirits of the former inhabitants remain in these houses as harmless, silent phantoms. They move in and out through the open doors and glide silently along the floors. The living and the dead move together in the same space, but the living are unaware of the presence of these spirits. The poet says that these spirits have no desire to frighten or harm us. They come as gentle reminders of a world before us, bridging the gap between the past and the present.

****2. Themes****

The continuity of life and death; the past always coexists with the present.

The idea that our homes hold the memories, essences, and perhaps the spirits of those who lived before.

Death is not a separation but a transformation, and the dead remain intimately connected to the world of the living.

****IMPORTANT QUESTIONS: HAUNTED HOUSES****

****Q1.**** Why does the poet say that all houses are haunted? Does he mean it in a frightening sense?

****Q2.**** Describe the "harmless phantoms" that the poet speaks of. How do they move and what do they do?

****Q3.**** What relationship does the poet draw between the living and the dead?

****Q4.**** Explain the lines: "We meet them at the doorway, on the stair, / Along the passages they come and go."

****Q5.**** What is the overall message or theme of the poem?

****Q6.**** How does Longfellow remove the element of fear typically associated with ghosts?

****POEM 2: THE GLOVE AND THE LIONS BY LEIGH HUNT****

****YouTube Lecture:**** <https://www.youtube.com/live/vxG2i1Pvnl0?si=aVW2S84UHAIASKES>

****1. Summary of the Poem****

The poem is set in a royal arena where King Francis and his nobles are watching a fierce lion fight. The lions are ferocious and deadly. The Count de Lorge is present with his lady love. To test his love and boast of her power over him, she deliberately throws her glove into the lion pit and asks him to retrieve it to prove his love. The Count leaps into the pit without hesitation, picks up the glove, and safely returns, winning the admiration of the King and the crowd. However, instead of giving the glove back to his lady with a lover's devotion, the Count throws the glove directly in her face. The King, instead of being angry, praises the Count's action, saying that it was the right deed to teach the lady a lesson about pride and vanity.

****2. Themes****

The theme of love versus pride. The lady's vanity leads to her humiliation.

The poem contrasts the nobility and bravery of the Count with the arrogance and folly of the lady.

The idea that true love does not demand foolish risks for the sake of a lover's vanity.

****IMPORTANT QUESTIONS: THE GLOVE AND THE LIONS****

****Q1.**** Describe the setting of the poem. What was happening in the arena?

****Q2.**** Why did the lady throw her glove into the lion pit?

****Q3.**** How did the Count react to her challenge? What did he do after retrieving the glove?

****Q4.**** Why do you think the Count threw the glove in the lady's face?

****Q5.**** What was King Francis's reaction to the Count's action? What does this reveal about the King's character?

****Q6.**** What is the central message of the poem?

****Q7.**** Analyse the character of the lady. Do you sympathise with her or condemn her?

****POEM 3: WHEN GREAT TREES FALL BY MAYA ANGELOU****

****YouTube Lecture:**** <https://www.youtube.com/live/vxG2i1PvnI0?si=aVW2S84UHAIASKES>

****1. Summary of the Poem****

The poem is an extended metaphor comparing the death of great human beings to the falling of great trees in a forest. When great trees fall, rocks on distant hills shudder, lions hunker down, and small creatures recoil in silence. In the same way, when a great soul dies, the entire human world and all our senses are affected. Our memory suddenly sharpens, and we remember every detail of our last meeting with them. The poet says that their absence leaves a great emptiness, and our reality is bound to be changed. When a great soul dies, "after a period peace blooms, slowly and always irregularly. Spaces fill with a kind of soothing electric vibration." The poem ends on a note of hope that peace and healing come gradually after great loss.

****2. Themes****

The impact of the death of great people: their passing changes the world and enriches our memory of them.

The process of mourning and eventual healing; peace returns gradually after great pain.

The interconnectedness of all beings: the death of a great soul affects everyone on a deep, spiritual level.

****IMPORTANT QUESTIONS: WHEN GREAT TREES FALL****

****Q1.**** What happens when great trees fall, according to the poet? What effect does it have on the natural world?

****Q2.**** Explain the metaphor of "great trees." What do they symbolise in relation to human beings?

****Q3.**** How does the death of a great soul affect our senses, according to Maya Angelou?

****Q4.**** What does the poet mean by saying, "After a period peace blooms"?

****Q5.**** Describe the healing process the poet speaks about. How do "spaces fill with a kind of soothing electric vibration"?

****Q6.**** What message does the poet convey about loss and recovery?

****POEM 4: A CONSIDERABLE SPECK BY ROBERT FROST****

****YouTube Lecture:**** <https://www.youtube.com/live/vxG2i1Pvnl0?si=aVW2S84UHAIASKES>

****1. Summary of the Poem****

The poet is writing at his desk when a tiny, living mite (a minute insect) alights on the white sheet of paper. The poet initially observes it with a scientific detachment, thinking it is too tiny to have any feelings or intelligence. He is about to kill it, but then he pauses. He observes that the mite runs across the paper, pauses as if it smells or tastes, and turns. The poet is fascinated by this tiny speck that "paused again and either drank or smelt." He recognises in this tiny creature a mind, an intelligence, and a will to live. He refuses to kill it, calling it a "living mite" with its own "design of living." He contrasts his own creative human mind with the limited but real mind of the mite. The poem ends with the poet letting the mite live.

****2. Themes****

The value of life, no matter how small or seemingly insignificant.

The intelligence and design present in all living creatures.

The conflict between human intellect and the natural instinct of survival.

The poet's compassion and refusal to destroy life.

****IMPORTANT QUESTIONS: A CONSIDERABLE SPECK****

****Q1.**** What was the poet doing when the mite appeared? Describe the mite's actions.

****Q2.**** What did the poet initially think about the mite? What made him change his mind about killing it?

****Q3.**** What does the poet mean by "a mind, / A living one, I could count on as much as mine"?

****Q4.**** Explain the significance of the title "A Considerable Speck." What makes the speck "considerable"?

****Q5.**** What is the poet's final attitude towards the mite? What does he decide to do and why?

****Q6.**** What message does Robert Frost convey about the value of life in this poem?

****POEM 5: THE POWER OF MUSIC BY SUKUMAR RAY****

****YouTube Lecture:**** <https://www.youtube.com/live/vxG2i1Pvnl0?si=aVW2S84UHAIASKES>

****1. Summary of the Poem****

The poem is a humorous piece about Bhisma Lochan Sharma, a man who sings in a voice so terrible that it causes chaos everywhere. He sings from Delhi to Burma, spreading his "music" across the land. His singing is described as a "power" that is not divine but diabolic. People, cattle, trees, and even non-living things react violently to his singing. The fish dive deeper, horses faint, buildings tremble, and people run away holding their ears. The poem is full of exaggerated, humorous imagery (hyperbole) showing the catastrophic effect of his loud, out-of-tune voice. The poem ends with the tongue-in-cheek suggestion that the only way to curb such a menace is to lock him up or ban his singing, because his voice has the power to drive the whole world mad.

****2. Themes****

The poem is a comic exaggeration of the effects of bad music (or any unpleasant noise).

It satirises those who believe they are talented but are actually a nuisance to everyone around them.

The poem highlights the power of sound and music to affect emotions, even if the effect here is entirely negative.

****IMPORTANT QUESTIONS: THE POWER OF MUSIC****

****Q1.**** Describe Bhisma Lochan Sharma and his singing. What effect did his music have on people, animals, and nature?

****Q2.**** Identify at least three humorous exaggerations (hyperboles) used in the poem to describe the effect of Bhisma's singing.

****Q3.**** What is the tone of the poem? Is it serious, sad, or humorous? Justify your answer.

****Q4.**** The poem is called "The Power of Music." What is the irony behind the title?

****Q5.**** How do different creatures react to Bhisma's voice? Describe the effects on at least two types of beings.

****Q6.**** What does the poet suggest should be done to stop Bhisma Lochan Sharma's singing?
